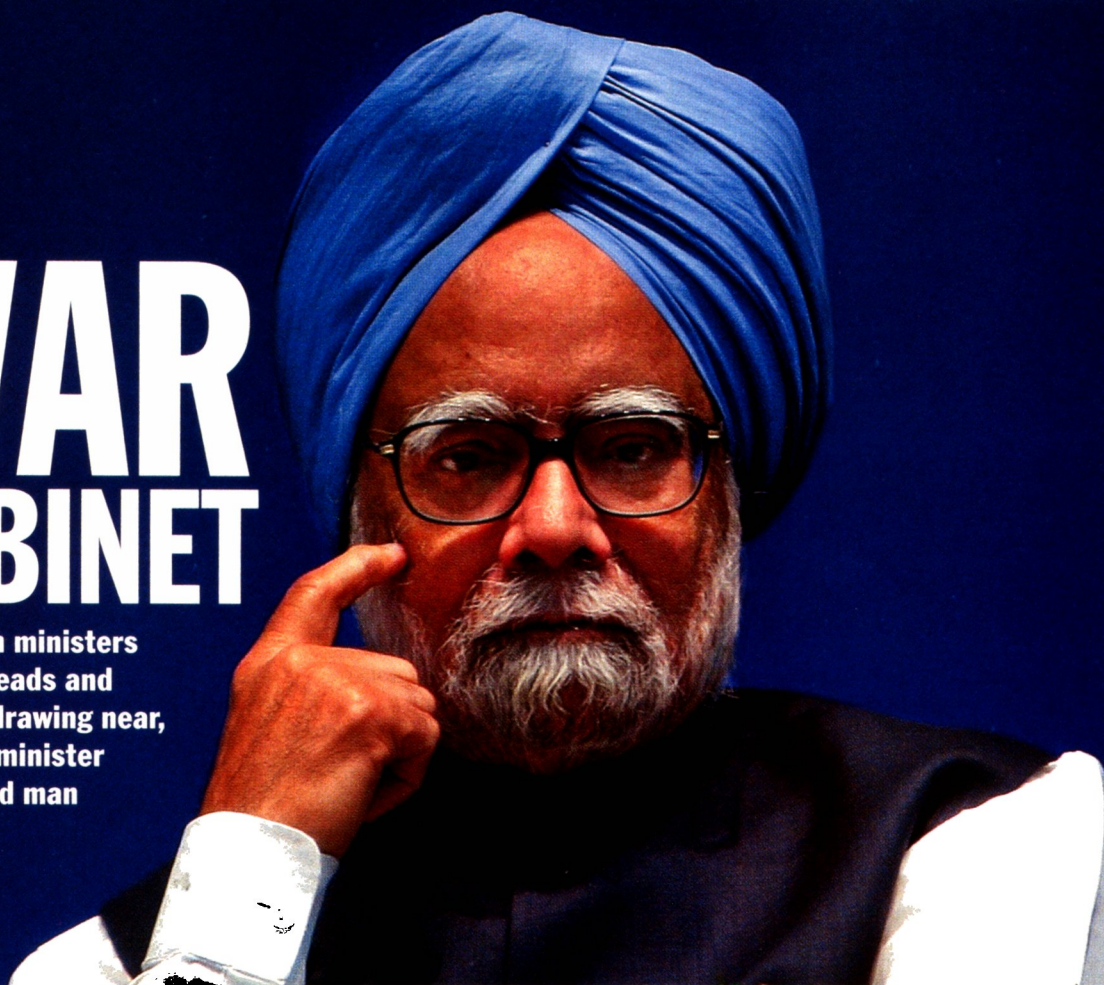


WAR CABINET

With Union ministers at loggerheads and elections drawing near, the prime minister is a worried man



■ **By Priya Sahgal**

It's a government under siege, both from outside and within. Whether it is the Jamia Nagar encounter, or the recent lay-offs in airlines, Union ministers are busy trading charges instead of collectively facing the Opposition. As a result, the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) is looking a little less united on the eve of a crucial round of state elections. Before taking off for Tokyo, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had reprimanded some of his warring ministers. He asked Petroleum Minister Murli Deora and Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel to sort out the matter of unpaid fuel bills of private airlines instead of raking up the issue in public. Manmohan directed Health Minister Anbumani Ramadoss and Home Minister Shivraj Patil to stop quibbling over the decriminalisation of homosexuality. Others like Labour Minister Oscar Fernandes

agree with Ramadoss, but a source in the Prime Minister's Office said Manmohan felt the time was not right to raise such contentious issues, now that his tenure is coming to an end.

But timing is all, unfortunately. With general elections not too far away, every minister is keen on a course correction and is batting for his own image rather than the

MANMOHAN SINGH IS UNDER PRESSURE FROM NOT JUST THE OPPOSITION BUT EVEN UPA ALLIES.

END GAME: Singh wants no discord as his tenure draws to a close

Government's collective standing.

Even a pro-Congress champion like Lalu Prasad Yadav is suddenly sounding disgruntled, whether over Patil's inept handling of the recent bomb blasts or the Jamia Nagar encounter. Yadav, along with the Samajwadi Party (SP), is leading the demand for a judicial probe in the matter. All this to Patil's dismay, who had taken credit for the entire episode with the Home Ministry turning his accidental visit to the police headquarters into a case study of a hands-on minister. Worse still, some Congressmen seem to agree with Yadav. Science and Technology Minister Kapil Sibal dropped in at Jamia Nagar, a part of his Muslim-dominated constituency, and commiserated with residents.

The DMK's pressure on the prime minister to intervene in the Sri Lankan